

EDUCATION IN INDIA

A Comprehensive Analysis of Structure, Challenges,
Reforms & the Road Ahead

BHARAT

SHIKSHA

REPORT 2025–26

Covering: Historical Roots • Policy Framework • Higher Education • Digital Revolution

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CHAPTER

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CHAPTER 1

Historical Evolution of Indian Education

From ancient Gurukuls to the modern university, India's educational journey spans more than 3,000 years.

Ancient & Classical Period (3000 BCE – 1200 CE)

India is the birthplace of formal education. The **Gurukul system** — where students lived with their teacher (Guru) — was the cornerstone of learning in the Vedic age. Knowledge of the Vedas, Upanishads, mathematics, astronomy, medicine (Ayurveda), logic, and philosophy was transmitted orally over years of residential study. The great universities of **Takshashila** (c. 700 BCE) and **Nalanda** (5th–12th century CE) attracted thousands of scholars from China, Persia, Korea, and Greece, making India a global intellectual hub.

- Takshashila housed over 10,000 students and 60+ subjects including law, medicine, and military science.
- Nalanda's library — the Dharmaganja — contained nine million manuscripts before its destruction in 1193 CE.
- Mathematics flourished: Aryabhata (476 CE) described zero and the decimal system; Brahmagupta advanced algebra.

Medieval & Mughal Period (1200–1757 CE)

With the arrival of Islamic rulers, **Madrasa** education spread across the subcontinent. Persian became the language of administration. Institutions in Delhi, Agra, and Lahore taught theology, philosophy, jurisprudence, and Persian literature. Despite political upheaval, a syncretic intellectual culture flourished, seen in the patronage of arts and sciences at Akbar's court.

Colonial Period (1757–1947) — Macaulay & Beyond

British colonial rule fundamentally restructured Indian education. **Lord Macaulay's Minute on Indian Education (1835)** explicitly aimed to create 'a class of persons, Indian in blood and colour, but English in taste, opinions, in morals, and in intellect.' The **Woods Despatch (1854)** established a university system on the London model; the first three universities at Calcutta, Bombay, and Madras were founded in 1857.

"We must at present do our best to form a class who may be interpreters between us and the millions whom we govern." — Lord Macaulay, 1835. This utilitarian vision shaped Indian education for a century.

Post-Independence Transformation (1947 Onwards)

After independence in 1947, the founding leaders — Nehru, Ambedkar, Azad — treated education as the instrument of nation-building. The **University Education Commission (1948)** under Dr. Sarvepalli

Radhakrishnan, the **Secondary Education Commission (1952)**, and the landmark **Kothari Commission (1964–66)** laid the philosophical and structural foundations of modern Indian education. The Kothari Commission famously recommended allocating **6% of GDP** to education — a target that remains largely unmet six decades later.

CHAPTER 2

Constitutional & Policy Framework

India's Constitution guarantees education as a right; a succession of policies has tried to translate that guarantee into reality.

Constitutional Provisions

The **Constitution of India (1950)** originally listed education in the Concurrent List (Schedule VII), meaning both Central and State governments could legislate on it. **Article 21A** (inserted by the 86th Amendment, 2002) made education a **Fundamental Right** for children aged 6–14. **Article 45** originally provided a directive to the State to provide free and compulsory education up to age 14 within ten years of the Constitution's commencement.

Article	Provision	Significance
Art. 21A	Free & Compulsory Education (6–14)	Fundamental Right since 2002
Art. 45	Early Childhood Care & Education	Directive Principle
Art. 46	Promotion of education of SC/ST	Directive Principle
Art. 30	Minorities' right to establish institutions	Fundamental Right
Art. 350A	Mother-tongue instruction	Directive Principle

Major Policy Milestones

India has had three major National Education Policies: **NPE 1968** (emphasised the 'three-language formula' and allocation of resources), **NPE 1986 / modified 1992** (introduced Operation Blackboard, Navodaya Vidyalayas, and the DPEP), and the transformative **NEP 2020**. The **Right to Education Act, 2009** gave legal teeth to Art. 21A, mandating free schooling, neighbourhood schools, and 25% reservation for disadvantaged children in private schools.

Key Regulatory Bodies

- **Ministry of Education (MoE)** — apex policy-making body (formerly HRD Ministry, renamed 2020).
- **University Grants Commission (UGC)** — regulates and funds higher education institutions.
- **AICTE** — All India Council for Technical Education, governing engineering and management colleges.
- **National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT)** — develops curricula and textbooks.
- **National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC)** — quality assurance in higher education.
- **National Board of Accreditation (NBA)** — accredits technical programmes.
- **CBSE & CISCE** — two major national school examination boards.

CHAPTER 3

Structure of the Education System

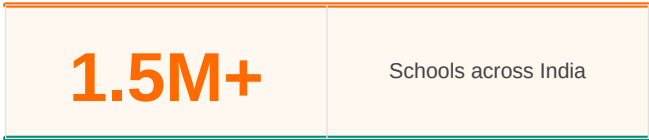
India's education system is among the largest in the world, serving 1.5 billion people through a layered architecture.

The 10+2+3 Framework (Legacy) and the New 5+3+3+4

For decades, India followed the **10+2+3** structure: 10 years of school (Classes I–X), 2 years of higher secondary (XI–XII), and 3 years of undergraduate study. The **NEP 2020** introduces a new school structure of **5+3+3+4** — aligned with child developmental stages: Foundational (ages 3–8), Preparatory (8–11), Middle (11–14), and Secondary (14–18). Undergraduate programmes shift to a **4-year** model with multiple entry/exit points.

Stage	Old System	NEP 2020	Age Group
Early Childhood	Informal / Anganwadi	Foundational (3 yrs)	3–6
Primary	Classes I–V	Foundational + Prep (5+3 yrs)	6–11
Upper Primary	Classes VI–VIII	Middle (3 yrs)	11–14
Secondary	Classes IX–X	Secondary (4 yrs)	14–18
Higher Secondary	Classes XI–XII	Integrated in Secondary	16–18
Undergraduate	3 years (BA/BSc/BCom)	4 years (flexible exit)	18–22
Postgraduate	2 years (MA/MSc)	1–2 years / integrated	22–24
Doctoral	PhD (3–5 years)	PhD (same, strengthened)	24+

Scale of the System



India operates the **largest higher education system by institution count** and the third largest by enrolment. The school network spans government, government-aided, and private unaided schools. States like Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Madhya Pradesh each manage more than 100,000 schools, making decentralised governance a formidable challenge.

CHAPTER 4

School Education — State & Challenges

India's 1.5 million schools are the backbone of the system — but quality, infrastructure, and learning outcomes remain deeply uneven.

Types of Schools

- **Government Schools** (~1.1M): Run by state/central governments; free education, mid-day meals, free textbooks.
- **Government-Aided Schools** (~85,000): Privately managed but receive government grants.
- **Private Unaided Schools** (~335,000): Self-financed; include elite CBSE/ICSE schools and low-fee private schools.
- **Central Schools (Kendriya Vidyalayas)**: 1,248 schools for central government employees' children.
- **Navodaya Vidyalayas (JNV)**: 661 residential schools for talented rural students, fully free.
- **Sainik Schools**: 33 schools preparing students for National Defence Academy.

Learning Outcomes — The Crisis

The **Annual Status of Education Report (ASER)**, published annually by Pratham since 2005, is the most authoritative grassroots survey of learning outcomes. Its findings are sobering: in 2023, only **50.5% of Class V students** in rural India could read a Class II-level text. In arithmetic, only **43.3% of Class V children** could correctly solve a two-digit subtraction problem. This 'learning poverty' is the defining crisis of Indian school education.

ASER 2023: Only 57.3% of Class VIII students could read a simple Class II text in English — a foundational skill expected years earlier. Despite near-universal enrolment, learning outcomes remain alarmingly low.

Indicator	2014	2018	2022	2023
Class V can read Std II text	48.1%	50.5%	42.8%	50.5%
Class III can do subtraction	25.3%	28.1%	25.9%	41.3%
Class VIII can do division	44.1%	44.1%	43.3%	47.0%
Schools with functioning toilets	65%	78%	84%	88%
Schools with electricity	45%	62%	71%	73%

Key Government Programmes

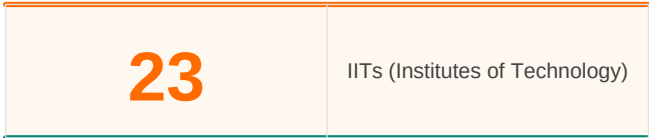
- **Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan:** Unified umbrella scheme merging SSA, RMSA, and Teacher Education; covers Classes Pre-school to XII.
- **PM POSHAN (Mid-Day Meal Scheme):** World's largest school feeding programme — 120 million children daily.
- **PM SHRI Schools:** 14,500 upgraded model schools exemplifying NEP 2020 pedagogy.
- **NIPUN Bharat (2021):** National Initiative for Proficiency in Reading with Understanding and Numeracy — targets foundational literacy by Grade 3.
- **Diksha Platform:** Digital Infrastructure for Knowledge Sharing — 3,000+ hours of e-content in 36 languages.

CHAPTER 5

Higher Education — IITs, IIMs & Universities

India's higher education sector is vast and varied — from world-class IITs to degree mills producing unemployable graduates.

Institutional Landscape



Indian higher education is categorised into **Central Universities** (54, funded by MoE), **State Universities** (430+), **Deemed Universities** (125+), and **Private Universities** (400+). The Institutes of National Importance — IITs, IIMs, NITs, AIIMS — are directly funded by the Centre and enjoy significant autonomy.

Institution Type	Count	Governing Act / Body	Notable Feature
IITs	23	IIT Act 1961	Institutes of National Importance
NITs	31	NIT Act 2007	State + Central funding
IIMs	21	IIM Act 2017	Autonomous Board of Governors
AIIMS	23	AIIMS Act 1956+	Premier medical schools
Central Universities	54	UGC Act / MoE	100% Central funding
State Universities	430+	State Acts	Majority of enrolments
Private Universities	400+	State Pvt Univ Acts	Fastest-growing segment
Deemed Universities	125+	UGC Act Sec 3	Specialised / niche focus

IITs — Global Reputation & Impact

The Indian Institutes of Technology are India's most globally recognised institutions. IIT Bombay, Delhi, and Madras consistently rank within the top 200–250 globally (QS 2025). IIT alumni have founded companies including Google, Sun Microsystems, and Infosys, and their remittances and intellectual contributions have shaped the global tech economy. The **JEE Advanced** examination, taken by ~180,000 students for ~17,000 seats, is among the world's most competitive entrance examinations.

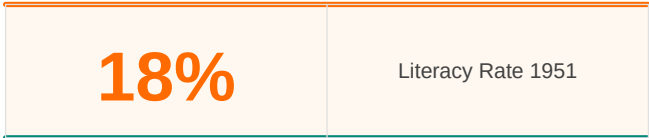
In 2024–25, the median domestic placement CTC at IIT Bombay exceeded █25 LPA; several offers topped █2 Crore per annum from global tech firms — a testament to the brand equity of IIT education.

CHAPTER 6

Literacy, Enrolment & Key Statistics

India has made remarkable strides since 1947 — yet significant gaps persist across gender, caste, and geography.

Literacy Trends



India's literacy rate grew from a dismal 18% at independence to an estimated 82% by 2024, representing one of history's largest expansions of education access. Yet in absolute terms, India still has the **largest population of non-literate adults** (~250 million), concentrated in Bihar, Rajasthan, Jharkhand, and Uttar Pradesh. The gender gap has narrowed — male literacy stands at ~87% vs female at ~77% — but remains significant in rural areas.

Gross Enrolment Ratios (GER)

Level	GER 2014–15	GER 2020–21	GER 2022–23	Target 2030
Primary (I–V)	99.2%	99.9%	~100%	100%
Upper Primary (VI–VIII)	90.5%	96.5%	98.2%	100%
Secondary (IX–X)	76.1%	79.8%	82.4%	90%
Higher Secondary (XI–XII)	51.4%	57.1%	58.0%	65%
Higher Education	24.5%	27.1%	28.4%	50%

Dropout Rates — A Persistent Challenge

Despite near-universal enrolment at primary level, **dropout rates spike sharply** at the transition from primary to secondary school. The all-India dropout rate at secondary level was 14.9% in 2021–22 (down from 17.5% in 2019–20). Financial pressure on families, particularly in agricultural states, forces children — especially girls — to leave school. The **pupil-teacher ratio** (PTR) nationally stands at 26:1 at primary level, but is critically high at 40:1 or more in states like Bihar and Uttar Pradesh.

CHAPTER 7

National Education Policy 2020

India's most sweeping education reform in 34 years — reimagining everything from preschool to PhD.

The **National Education Policy 2020** was approved by the Union Cabinet on 29 July 2020, replacing the previous NPE of 1986. Developed under a committee chaired by former ISRO chief Dr. K. Kasturirangan, the NEP 2020 is a 66-page document outlining transformative changes across all levels of education. Its four foundational pillars are: **Access, Equity, Quality, and Accountability**.

School Education Reforms

- **New 5+3+3+4 structure** aligned with developmental psychology and global best practices.
- **Mother-tongue instruction** in Grades 1–5 (at least), and flexibility to continue up to Grade 8.
- **Bag-less days**, vocational exposure from Grade 6, no rigid stream separation at secondary level.
- **Board examinations** to test core competencies, allowing two attempts per year.
- **Report cards as holistic progress cards** — 360-degree assessment including self, peer, and teacher evaluation.
- **Foundational Literacy & Numeracy Mission** — ensuring basic reading and arithmetic by Grade 3.

Higher Education Reforms

- **4-year multidisciplinary undergraduate programmes** with multiple entry and exit options (Certificate/Diploma/Degree/Honours with Research).
- **Academic Bank of Credits (ABC)**: Digital credit repository allowing credit transfer across institutions.
- **Higher Education Commission of India (HECI)**: Single umbrella body replacing UGC, AICTE, NCTE (separate for medical/legal).
- **Internationalisation**: Top foreign universities permitted to set up campuses in India.
- **Multidisciplinary Education & Research Universities (MERUs)**: Aim to create Indian institutions comparable to global research universities.
- **National Research Foundation (NRF)**: ₹50,000 Crore corpus to fund research over 5 years.

NEP 2020 targets raising the Gross Enrolment Ratio in higher education to 50% by 2035 — up from 28.4% today. This would require adding roughly 3.5 crore additional higher education seats over the next decade.

Implementation Status (2025)

As of 2025, implementation is uneven. The **Academic Bank of Credits** has over 2.5 crore registered students. **Common University Entrance Test (CUET)** — a single entrance test for 250+ Central and participating universities — has replaced individual university tests, with 15 lakh+ applications in 2024. The

4-year UG programme has been adopted by 200+ central and state universities. However, state-level adoption varies widely, and teacher training reforms remain behind schedule.

CHAPTER 8

Digital Education & the EdTech Revolution

The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated India's digital education journey by a decade — and a booming EdTech sector is reshaping how India learns.

Government Digital Initiatives

- **PM e-VIDYA:** Multi-mode access — one dedicated TV channel per grade (1–12), radio content, and digital portals.
- **SWAYAM (Study Webs of Active Learning for Young Aspiring Minds):** India's MOOC platform — 2,800+ courses, 25 million enrolments.
- **SWAYAM Prabha:** 34 DTH channels broadcasting 24/7 educational content from NPTEL, IITs, and UGC.
- **DIKSHA:** National platform for school digital content — 4 billion+ learning sessions; content in 36 languages.
- **National Digital Library of India (NDLI):** 90 million+ educational resources curated by IIT Kharagpur.
- **e-Pathshala:** NCERT's mobile app providing free digital textbooks, audiobooks, and videos.
- **NPTEL:** 2,000+ engineering & science courses from IITs and IISc — globally top-ranked on Coursera.

The EdTech Boom & Correction

India's EdTech sector — powered by the world's **largest youth population**, cheap mobile data (thanks to Jio's 2016 disruption), and the COVID lockdown — exploded between 2019–2022. Companies like **BYJU'S**, **Vedantu**, **Unacademy**, **upGrad**, **Physics Wallah**, and **Doubtnut** raised billions in venture capital. At its peak, BYJU'S was valued at \$22 billion (2022), making it the world's most valued EdTech company.

However, 2023–24 saw a severe **EdTech correction**: BYJU'S faced insolvency proceedings, massive layoffs swept the sector, and investor enthusiasm cooled after concerns about aggressive sales practices, inflated valuations, and poor learning outcomes. **Physics Wallah**, with its low-cost model (■999 courses), emerged as the preferred unicorn — valued at \$2.8 billion in 2023.

Platform	Founded	Focus	Users/Status (2024)
BYJU'S	2011	K-12 & Entrance Exam	Insolvency proceedings; 150M+ registered
Physics Wallah	2014	JEE/NEET Coaching	\$2.8B valuation; 10M+ active learners
Unacademy	2015	Competitive Exams	~50M registered users
upGrad	2015	Higher Ed / Upskilling	\$2.25B valuation
Vedantu	2014	Live tutoring K-12	Restructured; ~35M users

Platform	Founded	Focus	Users/Status (2024)
SWAYAM (Govt)	2017	UG/PG MOOCs	25M+ enrolments

CHAPTER 9

Vocational Education & Skill Development

India has the demographic dividend but faces an acute skills mismatch — vocational education is the bridge.

The Skills Gap

India adds approximately **12 million people to its workforce annually**. Yet the National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC) estimates that only 5.4% of India's workforce aged 15–59 has received formal vocational training, compared to 52% in the USA, 75% in Germany, and 80% in Japan. This skills deficit threatens India's ambition to become a \$5 trillion economy.

Key Institutions & Programmes

- **Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs)**: 15,000+ institutes offering 2-year trade certificates; 2.4 million enrolments annually.
- **Polytechnics**: 3-year diploma programmes in engineering; 1.5 million students.
- **PM Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY)**: Flagship skilling scheme — 14 million+ trained since 2015.
- **Skill India Mission (2015)**: Target to skill 400 million people by 2022 (partially achieved); now extended.
- **National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC)**: PPP body; 40+ sector skill councils.
- **Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Kendras (PMKK)**: Model skill centres in every parliamentary constituency.

NEP 2020 mandates that at least 50% of learners go through vocational education at some point by 2025. Integration of vocational courses from Grade 6 onwards — including coding, carpentry, pottery, gardening — aims to destigmatise skill-based careers.

Apprenticeship & Industry Connect

The **National Apprenticeship Promotion Scheme (NAPS)** incentivises industry to hire apprentices by reimbursing 25% of the prescribed stipend. India has 0.5 million registered apprentices — far below China's 20 million. The **Apprenticeship (Amendment) Act 2014** expanded eligible trades and reduced penalties on employers. New models like **Earn While You Learn** and sector-specific clusters (textiles in Tiruppur, gems in Surat, auto in Pune) are gaining traction.

CHAPTER 10

Gender, Equity & Inclusion

Widening access is not enough — India must ensure that education serves its most marginalised communities.

Gender Parity in Education

India has made remarkable progress in gender parity at primary level — the **Gender Parity Index (GPI)** at primary level reached 1.04 (girls slightly outnumber boys) in 2022–23. However, the GPI drops to 0.94 at secondary and 0.96 at higher education level. In STEM fields, women constitute only 42% of science enrolments and a significantly lower share in engineering and technology programmes (28%).

Scheme	Objective	Coverage
Beti Bachao Beti Padhao	Improve sex ratio & girl's education	161 districts; national campaign
Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya	Residential schools for minority/SC/ST girls	~5,000 schools
Mahila Samakhya	Women's empowerment & literacy	10 states
UDAAN (CBSE)	Bridge gifted girls to IIT-JEE	National; CBSE schools
PM Matru Vandana Yojana	Maternity benefit to encourage enrolment	~3 crore beneficiaries

Inclusion of SC, ST & OBC Communities

India's **reservation policy** in higher education mandates 22.5% reservation for SCs and STs (7.5%+15%) and 27% for OBCs in Central institutions, established by the 77th and 93rd Constitutional Amendments. This has significantly increased representation — yet outcomes remain inequitable: dropout rates for ST students at university level are three times higher than the general population, reflecting socioeconomic barriers beyond mere admission.

Education for Children with Disabilities

The **Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016** and the **RTE Act** mandate inclusive education for children with disabilities in neighbourhood schools. The **Samagra Shiksha** scheme funds special educators, resource rooms, assistive devices, and barrier-free infrastructure. Yet, only 28.9 lakh children with disabilities were enrolled in school in 2021–22 — many more remain out of school or in segregated special schools.

CHAPTER 11

Funding, Budget & International Comparison

India invests less in education per capita than peer nations — and the consequences are visible in outcomes.

Education Budget Trends

India has historically struggled to meet the Kothari Commission's recommendation of **6% of GDP** on education. Public education expenditure has hovered around 4.4–4.6% of GDP — rising from 3.1% in 2014–15. The Union Budget 2024–25 allocated **■1.20 lakh crore** to the Ministry of Education — 2.5% of the Union Budget, up from **■99,311 crore** in 2023–24.

Year	MoE Allocation (■ Cr)	% of Union Budget	% of GDP (Public)
2019–20	94,853	2.97%	3.1%
2020–21	99,311	2.9%	3.1%
2021–22	93,224	2.5%	2.9%
2022–23	1,04,278	2.6%	3.2%
2023–24	1,12,899	2.5%	~3.5%
2024–25	1,20,627	2.5%	~4.6% (incl. state)

International Comparison

Country	Edu. Spend (% GDP)	Literacy Rate	HE GER	PISA Rank (approx.)
India	4.6%	82%	28%	N/A (non-participant)
China	4.2%	97%	58%	Top 5 (Shanghai)
USA	5.5%	99%	88%	~25th
Finland	6.8%	100%	92%	Top 5
Brazil	6.2%	94%	51%	~60th
South Korea	5.1%	98%	98%	Top 10
Germany	4.9%	99%	72%	~20th

India's most glaring gap is in **Higher Education GER (28% vs 50%+ in developed nations)** and in **research and innovation output**. While India produces the third largest number of researchers globally,

R&D investment at 0.65% of GDP is far below the global average of 1.8% — hampering breakthrough innovation.

CHAPTER 12

Quality, Rankings & Research Output

India punches below its weight in global rankings — but green shoots of research excellence are emerging.

Global Rankings Performance

In the **QS World University Rankings 2025**, IIT Bombay ranked 118th — India's highest-ever QS ranking. IIT Delhi (197), IIT Madras (227), and IISc Bangalore (211) are the other top performers. India has 46 institutions in the QS 2025 list — up from 35 in 2021 — reflecting improved research output and academic reputation. However, India's institutions struggle with poor faculty-to-student ratios (limiting the 'faculty citations' metric) and limited international collaboration.

Institution	QS 2025 Rank	THE 2025 Rank	NIRF 2024 (India)
IIT Bombay	118	351–400	3
IISc Bangalore	211	251–300	1 (Research)
IIT Delhi	197	401–500	2
IIT Madras	227	601–800	1 (Overall)
IIT Kharagpur	222	601–800	5
University of Delhi	328	1001+	11
JNU	601–650	1001+	2 (University)

Research Output & Innovation

India's research output has grown dramatically: from 60,000 publications in 2010 to over **3 lakh (300,000) per year in 2023**, making India the 3rd largest producer of research papers globally (after the USA and China). However, **citation impact** — quality of research — remains below global average. India's **Global Innovation Index (GII) rank** improved from 81st (2015) to **39th (2023)**, driven by ICT services, venture capital, and creative output.

ANRF (Anusandhan National Research Foundation): Established under NEP 2020 with a **₹50,000 crore corpus over 5 years**, ANRF aims to transform India's research ecosystem by funding high-impact science, technology, and social science research — with an emphasis on industry-academia collaboration.

CHAPTER 13

Challenges & Critical Issues

Despite decades of progress, deep structural problems threaten the quality and equity of Indian education.

1. The Teacher Crisis

India faces a **dual teacher crisis**: quantitative shortage and qualitative deficit. The **Unified District Information System for Education Plus (UDISE+) 2022–23** reports 1.17 million teacher vacancies in government schools. Teacher absenteeism in rural government schools averages 25–30% on any given day (World Bank). B.Ed. programmes — the entry gateway to teaching — are widely criticised for being rote-learning exercises rather than professional training. The **National Teacher Platform (NISHTHA)** has trained 4.5 million teachers, but deep pedagogical transformation remains elusive.

2. Examination Culture & Coaching Factories

India's high-stakes examination system — JEE, NEET, UPSC, State PCS — has spawned a **■58,000 crore** coaching industry. **Kota, Rajasthan**, has become the global symbol of exam coaching, hosting 200,000+ students annually. The psychological toll is severe: Kota reports 20–25 student suicides per year. The extreme competition for limited elite seats creates anxiety, rote-learning, and a narrow definition of success. NEP 2020 attempts to address this by reforming board examinations and diversifying pathways — but cultural change is slower than policy.

3. Graduate Employability

A **NASSCOM survey** found that only 25% of Indian engineering graduates are directly employable — the rest require 6–12 months of additional training by employers. The **India Skills Report 2024** indicates overall employability at 54.8%. The mismatch arises from curriculum disconnected from industry needs, inadequate practical/project-based learning, and proliferation of low-quality colleges awarding degrees without adding skills.

4. The Rural–Urban Divide

A child in a Delhi private school and a child in a government school in rural Jharkhand inhabit entirely different educational universes. The former has air-conditioned classrooms, science labs, and 1:1 device access; the latter may attend a single-teacher, multi-grade school with no electricity. The **per-student expenditure** in top private schools is 50–100x that in rural government schools. Digital education has widened rather than narrowed this gap in many regions, as rural children lack devices and connectivity.

5. Higher Education Quality Proliferation

The rapid expansion of private colleges — particularly in states like Telangana, Maharashtra, and Tamil Nadu — has created a long tail of low-quality institutions granting degrees without adequate faculty, infrastructure, or academic rigour. Regulatory capture, ghost colleges, and degree mills undermine the value of Indian qualifications. **NAAC accreditation** has only covered 30% of eligible institutions, leaving

the majority unassessed.

CHAPTER 14

The Way Forward — Vision 2047

As India approaches its centenary of independence, education holds the key to realising its aspirations as a developed nation.

Strategic Priorities for 2025–2047

- **Foundational Learning First:** Aggressive implementation of NIPUN Bharat; every child reading and calculating by Grade 3 is non-negotiable.
- **Teacher Professionalism:** Competitive salaries, rigorous selection, continuous professional development (CPD), and performance management for teachers.
- **Full NEP 2020 Implementation:** Especially the Academic Bank of Credits, multidisciplinary education, and mother-tongue instruction.
- **Research & Innovation Ecosystem:** ANRF fully operational; India in the Global Top 25 Innovation Index by 2035.
- **Higher Education GER to 50%:** Requires 1,000+ new colleges and massive expansion of online/hybrid delivery.
- **Skilling at Scale:** 50% of youth in formal vocational training by 2030; apprenticeship to 5 million.
- **Closing the Digital Divide:** Universal broadband in all schools; 1 device per student in government schools by 2027.
- **Global Partnerships:** 5 Indian universities in QS Top 100 by 2035; bilateral recognition agreements with 50+ countries.

India's Demographic Dividend — A Closing Window

India's median age of 28.4 years makes it the **youngest large economy on earth**. The working-age population (15–64) will peak around 2041. This demographic dividend — ~1 billion people in the productive age group — can either propel India to economic leadership or, if unskilled and undereducated, create a **demographic disaster**. The World Economic Forum estimates that India must educate and skill 500 million people over the next 15 years to capture this window. Education is not just a social service — it is India's most critical economic strategy.

"Education is not the filling of a pail, but the lighting of a fire." — W.B. Yeats. India's challenge is to light that fire in 250 million classrooms — and to ensure the flames of curiosity, critical thinking, and creativity burn equally bright in every village and every city.

Key Performance Indicators — National Targets

Indicator	Current (2024–25)	Target 2030	Target 2047
Education spend (% GDP)	4.6%	6%	7%+
Higher Ed GER	28.4%	50%	65%
Literacy Rate	~82%	90%	99%+
Secondary GER	82%	90%	98%
Teacher vacancies	1.17M	<500,000	<100,000
QS Top 100 institutions	0	2–3	5+
GII Rank	39th	25th	Top 15
Youth with vocational training	5.4%	25%	50%

Conclusion: India's education system stands at a historic inflection point. The legislative architecture — from RTE to NEP 2020 — is largely in place. The challenge is now one of implementation, political will, and cultural transformation. A nation that educates all its children well — not just the privileged — will be unstoppable. The next 25 years will determine whether India's demographic dividend becomes its greatest asset or its most profound missed opportunity.

— End of Report —